

Introduction to Microsoft Excel

Understanding the environment and getting set up

1. What Is Excel?

Microsoft Excel is a spreadsheet application used to organize, calculate, analyze, and visualize data. It arranges information into a grid of rows and columns, where each intersection (a **cell**) can hold text, numbers, dates, or formulas. Excel is widely used for budgeting, financial modeling, data tracking, reporting, and building charts and dashboards.

Common everyday uses include:

- Tracking expenses and building personal or business budgets
- Creating schedules, calendars, and to-do lists
- Performing calculations automatically with formulas and functions
- Analyzing data with sorting, filtering, and pivot tables
- Building charts and graphs to visualize trends

2. Understanding the Excel Environment

Before entering data, it helps to know the main parts of the Excel window. Each area serves a specific purpose in how you interact with your workbook.

Element	What It Does
Quick Access Toolbar	A customizable strip at the very top for frequently used commands like Save, Undo, and Redo.
Ribbon	The main command center, organized into tabs (Home, Insert, Page Layout, Formulas, Data, Review, View) each holding related tools in groups.
Name Box	Displays the reference of the selected cell (e.g., A1) and lets you jump to a specific cell or named range.
Formula Bar	Shows and lets you edit the actual content — text, number, or formula — of the selected cell.
Worksheet Grid	The rows (numbered) and columns (lettered) of cells where you enter and organize data.

Element	What It Does
Sheet Tabs	Located at the bottom, these let you switch between worksheets within the same workbook.
Status Bar	Along the bottom edge, it shows quick info like sums/averages of a selection, zoom controls, and view options.

Key Terms to Know

- **Workbook** — an entire Excel file, which can contain multiple worksheets
- **Worksheet (sheet)** — a single page/tab within a workbook made up of rows and columns
- **Cell** — a single box in the grid, identified by its column letter and row number (e.g., B4)
- **Cell Range** — a group of selected cells, written as a start and end cell (e.g., A1:C10)
- **Active Cell** — the currently selected cell, outlined with a bold border

● Tip

You can quickly jump to any cell by typing its reference into the Name Box and pressing Enter — useful for navigating large worksheets without scrolling.

3. Setting Up Excel

Getting Access to Excel

Excel is available in a few different forms, so pick the one that fits your needs:

- **Microsoft 365 (subscription)** — installed desktop app for Windows or Mac, always kept up to date, includes cloud storage via OneDrive
- **Excel 2021/2024 (one-time purchase)** — a standalone installed version without a subscription
- **Excel for the web** — a free, browser-based version accessible with a Microsoft account at office.com; slightly fewer advanced features
- **Excel mobile app** — available for phones and tablets, useful for quick edits and viewing on the go

First-Time Setup Steps

- 1 **Sign in with a Microsoft account.** This links your saved files, settings, and OneDrive storage across devices.
- 2 **Open Excel and choose a starting point.** You'll see the Start screen with a Blank Workbook option and a selection of templates (budgets, calendars, invoices, etc.).
- 3 **Create a new workbook.** Click **Blank Workbook** to open an empty grid ready for data entry.

- 4 **Familiarize yourself with the Ribbon tabs.** Click through Home, Insert, Page Layout, Formulas, Data, Review, and View to see what each offers.
- 5 **Save your file.** Use **File > Save As**, choose a location (your device or OneDrive), name the file, and keep the default **.xlsx** format for full compatibility with modern Excel features.

Adjusting Basic Settings

A few settings are worth checking early on, found under **File > Options**:

- **General** — set your default font, font size, and the number of sheets a new workbook starts with
- **Save** — set how often AutoRecover saves a backup copy and the default file format
- **Quick Access Toolbar** — add commands you use often (like Print Preview or Spelling) for one-click access
- **Formulas** — control calculation options, such as automatic vs. manual recalculation

Understanding File Formats

Format	Use Case
.xlsx	The standard modern Excel format; supports all current features
.xlsm	Same as .xlsx but supports macros (automated scripts)
.csv	A plain-text, comma-separated format useful for importing/exporting data between programs
.xls	An older Excel format, kept mainly for compatibility with older versions

● Tip

Turn on AutoSave (top-left corner) when working from OneDrive so your changes save continuously and you never lose progress.

4. Quick-Start Checklist

- 1 Open Excel and create a new blank workbook
- 2 Click a cell and type data, then press Enter or Tab to move to the next cell
- 3 Explore the Home tab to format text (bold, color, alignment)
- 4 Try a simple formula, such as typing **=SUM(A1:A5)** into a cell
- 5 Rename a sheet tab by double-clicking it
- 6 Save your workbook using Ctrl+S (Windows) or Cmd+S (Mac)

With the environment and setup covered, you're ready to start entering data and exploring formulas, formatting, and charts in more depth.